Little Fox Readers

Level 5

Journey to the West 1
The Monkey



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From the beginning of time, a rock had sat high on top of a mountain. The sun, the moon, Heaven, and Earth all worked their magic on the rock. One day the rock split open. Inside was a monkey.

The monkey stood up and stretched. Suddenly powerful light shot from his eyes. For a moment the light reached the Cloud Palace in Heaven.



The Jade Emperor, ruler of Heaven, sat up. He turned to one of his captains, who was standing nearby.

"Find out what caused that light," said the emperor.

"Yes, Your Majesty," said the captain.

The captain rushed out of the hall. He looked out the southern gate of Heaven and saw the monkey on Earth below. The



light was gone. But the captain had magical sight. He could see everything that had just happened.

"Interesting," said the captain.

"Well?" said the Jade Emperor when the captain returned. "What caused the light?"

"It was a monkey," said the captain.

"A monkey?" asked the Jade Emperor.

"Yes," said the captain. "He's on the



Fruit and Flower Mountain, down on Earth. There had been a rock on the mountain. The monkey came from the rock. The light shone from the monkey's eyes."

The emperor thought for a moment and then shrugged. "I'm not surprised," he said. "Amazing things happen when Heaven and Earth work together."

As time passed, Monkey learned to walk,



run, and climb. He drank from streams and ate grasses and leaves. He gathered fruit and explored caves and mountaintops. He became friends with all the other monkeys and apes. At night he slept under a cliff.

One very hot morning, all the monkeys and apes were playing in the shade.

"It is so hot today!" cried one monkey. "Let's play in the stream."



"Good idea!" said another monkey.

The monkeys and apes ran to the stream. The water rolled and bounced over the rocks.

The monkeys jumped into the cool water. Everyone splashed and played.

After a few minutes, one monkey scratched her head. "We all love this stream," she said. "We drink from it. We swim in it. We know that it flows all the way to the



ocean. But does anyone know where the stream begins?"

They all looked at one another and shook their heads.

"We have nothing to do today," the monkey continued. "Why don't we follow the stream to find its source?"

"That sounds like fun," said another monkey.



"Let's go!" said a third monkey.

Everyone jumped out of the water. They ran alongside the stream and swung from tree to tree. They jumped over rocks and climbed up steep cliffs. Higher and higher they went up the mountain until they reached an enormous waterfall. Mist filled the air. The water crashed down, roaring like thunder.

"I wonder what's behind that waterfall,"



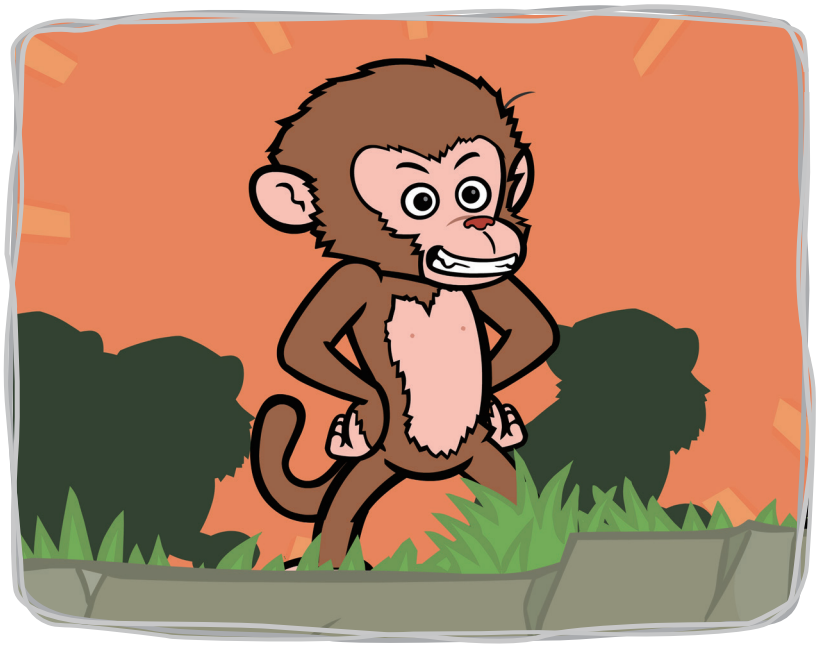
said one monkey.

"Me too," said a second monkey. "But nobody could jump through it."

"Whoever can jump through and come back alive will be our king," said a gibbon. "Is anyone brave enough to try?"

All the monkeys and apes looked at one another. They shook their heads.

"I'm not going to try," said a tall monkey.



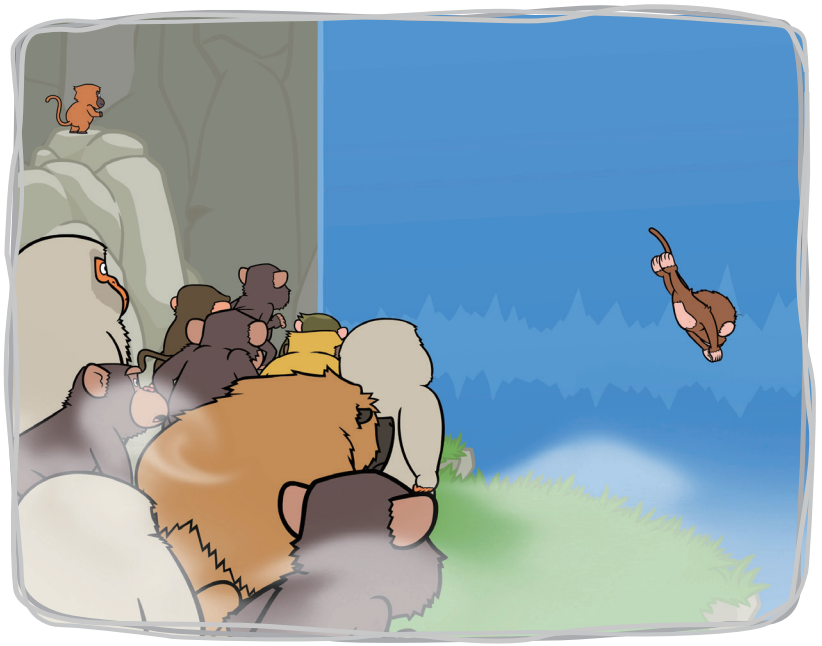
"Me neither," said a short monkey.

A voice called out, "I'll do it!"

Everyone moved out of the way as the speaker stepped forward. It was Monkey.

"Are you sure?" asked the gibbon. "It looks dangerous."

Monkey laughed. "I'm not afraid of anything! And when I come back, I will be king!"



Monkey took a deep breath and leaped into the waterfall.